

Psalms 61

The Rock That Is Higher Than I

Lead me to the rock that is higher than I

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Hear my cry, O God; attend unto my prayer.
- 2 From the end of the earth will I cry unto thee, when my heart is overwhelmed: lead me to the rock that is higher than I.
- 3 For thou hast been a shelter for me, and a strong tower from the enemy.
- 4 I will abide in thy tabernacle for ever: I will trust in the covert of thy wings. Selah.
- 5 For thou, O God, hast heard my vows: thou hast given me the heritage of those that fear thy name.
- 6 Thou wilt prolong the king's life: and his years as many generations.
- 7 He shall abide before God for ever: O prepare mercy and truth, which may preserve him.
- 8 So will I sing praise unto thy name for ever, that I may daily perform my vows.

2 • CONTEXT

A shorter psalm of David, likely written in exile or distance from the sanctuary (v. 2, "from the end of the earth"), asking for shelter and long life for the king, suggesting either David's own reign or intercession for it. Henry highlights the image of the "rock higher than I"—a refuge beyond one's own reach or strength, requiring God to lead him there.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

"Hear my cry, O God... From the end of the earth will I cry unto thee, when my heart is overwhelmed: lead me to the rock that is higher than I." Distance and being overwhelmed do not prevent prayer; instead they intensify the plea for a refuge beyond his own strength to reach.

Verse 3-5

Confidence in past faithfulness: "Thou hast been a shelter for me, and a strong tower from the enemy." He resolves to abide in God's tabernacle forever and trust "in the covert of thy wings," recalling vows already made and heard.

Verse 6-8

Intercession, likely for the king: "Thou wilt prolong the king's life... mercy and truth, which may preserve him." He vows to "sing praise to thy name for ever" and "daily perform" his vows in ongoing worship, not one-time relief.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

When overwhelmed and far from familiar supports, true refuge is a "rock higher than I"—beyond self-generated strength—that God alone leads a person to; and that personal refuge extends naturally into ongoing worship and intercession for others, such as a king or leader.

Application for life today.

When emotionally or geographically distant from support, remember prayer still reaches God "from the end of the earth." Ask specifically to be led to a refuge "higher" than your own coping strategies. Let personal experience of shelter turn into intercession—pray for leaders' preservation the way David does here, not only for your own needs.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. When you feel "overwhelmed" and distant from support, how does verse 2's prayer to be led to a "higher" rock guide you?

2. What past experiences of God as "shelter" and "strong tower" can you draw on now?

3. Who in leadership over you could you intercede for this week, as David does for the king?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).